

Mongolia



Landlocked between Russia and China, Mongolia is a huge, isolated, and sparsely populated nation. Over two-thirds of the country is part of the Gobi Desert.



GEOGRAPHY

A mountainous steppe plateau in the north, with lakes in the north and west. The desert region of the Gobi dominates the south.



CLIMATE

Continental. Mild summers and long, dry, very cold winters, with heavy snowfall. Temperatures can drop as low as -22°F (-30°C).



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Mongolia was unified by Genghis Khan in 1206 and was later absorbed into Manchu China. A majority of ethnic Mongolians live within China in Inner Mongolia. Tibetan Buddhism dominates. The traditional, nomadic way of life has been eroded as urban migration continues, spurred by ferocious winters, known as *zud*, which can devastate the rural economy.

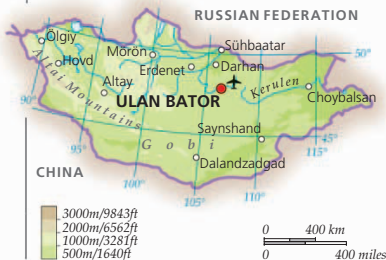


THE ECONOMY

Rich deposits of oil, coal, copper, uranium, and other minerals remain largely untapped. Cashmere exports. Democracy, from 1990, brought a shift toward a market economy, but also rising poverty. State involvement in mining is an issue. Agriculture uses 40% of workforce, mainly as herders.



INSIGHT: *Horseracing, wrestling, and archery are the national sports*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Mongolia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1924

CAPITAL: Ulan Bator

POPULATION: 2.67 million

TOTAL AREA: 604,247 sq. miles
(1,565,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 4 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Khalkha Mongolian*, other

RELIGIONS: Tibetan Buddhist 96%,
Muslim 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Khalkh 82%, other 9%,
Kazakh 4%, Dorvod 3%, Bayad 2%

GOVERNMENT: Mixed presidential–
parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Tugrik (tögrög) = 100 mōngö